"How Can We Tell When Mom Needs More Help?" and Other Questions Families Ask When Planning Ahead

Eight general questions answered plainly, and who to ask about the rest.

You've been turning the same few questions over for a while now. Other families ask them too. Here they are, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about Mom in particular. Where the honest answer is that it depends on her, on your state or on the situation, the answer says so and says who to ask.

1 How can we tell when Mom needs more help?

There isn't a line a family can read off a list, and this guide won't draw one. What you can do is notice and write down. The federal Administration for Community Living suggests asking an older loved one whether it is getting more difficult to do things she used to do easily and whether she has trouble remembering to take her medications, and noticing whether she holds onto walls or furniture when walking or has difficulty getting up from a chair. What those add up to for Mom is a question for her health care provider. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've noticed a change and can't tell whether it matters. Describe what you saw to her doctor and let them judge.

2 Is what we're seeing just normal aging?

Sometimes, and a family usually can't tell which. On memory, MedlinePlus says that as people grow older it may take longer to remember things, and that it's normal to forget things once in a while: a name, where the keys are. It also says that forgetting how to use the phone or find the way home may be signs of a more serious problem. For other kinds of change there is no general rule to give you. It depends on Mom. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** Mom is worried about her memory, or you are. MedlinePlus's advice to a person worried about forgetfulness is to see a health care provider, and her doctor is the one to hear what you've noticed.

3 What kinds of care might she eventually need?

Nobody can say that from here, and a guide shouldn't guess. In general, long-term care is a range of services and supports, and most of it is not medical care but help with the basic personal tasks of everyday life. It can be provided at home, in the community or in a facility. Most of it is provided at home, and for many people a blended approach works best. [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know what Mom's own health may mean for the years ahead. That is a question for her doctor.

4 What's the difference between home care, assisted living and a nursing home, and how would we know which fits?

Care at home may come from family and friends, or from a nurse, an aide or a therapist who comes to the house. Assisted living is housing and services for people who need some help with daily care but do not need the medical care that a nursing home provides. Nursing homes provide the most comprehensive range of services, including nursing care and around-the-clock supervision. Which would fit Mom, and when, depends on her needs, your state and the providers near her. [4] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the question becomes which one is right for her. The clinicians who assess her and the providers themselves can answer that. A general guide can't.

5 How do we bring this up with Mom?

Pick a quiet, unhurried time and ask open questions: where she would prefer to receive care if she ever needed more help, how important staying in her own home is, what she would expect from family, and who she wants involved in decisions. Write down what she says in her own words. The Administration for Community Living notes that most people prefer to remain in their homes for as long as possible, but Mom's own answer is the one that counts. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** her answers raise a question about her health, or about what a kind of care involves. Write it down and take it to her doctor or to a provider.

6 What should we start on now, while there's time?

The family's part is small and concrete. Write down how Mom is doing today, with the date. List the help she already gets and who gives it. Ask her what she would want, and note it in her words. Keep a list of the questions you can't answer, with who each one goes to. That is a picture. It isn't a plan yet, and decisions about care, money and legal documents come later, each with the right professional.

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a question on your list is about her health (her doctor), her medications (her pharmacist), or how care might be paid for in your state (your Medicaid planner).

7 Will Medicare pay for long-term care?

Generally not. Medicare.gov says Medicare generally doesn't cover long-term care in a nursing home, and the Administration for Community Living says Medicare does not pay for non-skilled help with activities of daily living, which make up the majority of long-term care services. Medicare does cover certain skilled nursing facility services on a short-term basis. What it would cover in a particular case depends on the situation. [6] [7] [8] [9]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you need to know what Medicare would cover for a particular service. Ask her doctor and Medicare, or her plan if she has a Medicare Advantage plan.

8 What does long-term care cost, and where does Medicaid come in?

The cost depends on the type and duration of care a person needs, the provider, and where she lives, so no general figure would tell you much about Mom. Medicaid is a joint federal and state program that helps some people pay for health care, including long-term care in nursing homes and at home. Its eligibility rules and the services it covers vary from state to state, so this guide doesn't describe them. [10] [11]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know how the rules work in your state or for your family. That is a question for your Medicaid planner. The Administration for Community Living also names the State Medical Assistance office as the best source of information on how to qualify in your state.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Mom herself, and it states no rule, figure or deadline for any state. It isn't medical, legal, financial or tax advice. Anything that depends on her health, your state or your family's situation needs someone who knows it.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions. The care interview is where the questions become about Mom: it walks you through her situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Avoiding a Fall
2. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Memory | MedlinePlus
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Where Can You Receive Care?
5. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Assisted Living: MedlinePlus
6. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
7. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Planning Ahead After Age 65
8. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), SNF Care Coverage
9. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Nursing Home Coverage
10. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Costs of Care
11. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid